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GUIDELINES ON TRAVEL & REIMBURSEMENT MANAGEMENT

DOCUMENT HISTORY

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The objective of the Travel C Reimbursement Management guidelines at Arche Global is to establish a clear framework for planning, executing, and reimbursing business travel in a manner that is:

Efficient: Ensures optimal use of resources by defining cost-effective and practical travel practices.

Compliant: Aligns with company policies, regulatory requirements, and financial standards.

Transparent: Provides clarity on approval processes, reimbursable expenses, and employee responsibilities.

Sustainable: Encourages eco-friendly travel choices to reduce environmental impact.

Safe: Prioritizes employee safety and security during domestic and international travel.

By adhering to these guidelines, employees and the organization can ensure smooth travel experiences that support business objectives while maintaining accountability and efficiency.

Responsibilities in Adherence to Travel Guidelines

To ensure seamless implementation and compliance with travel guidelines, the following roles and responsibilities are defined for key stakeholders:

People Excellence Team

- **Policy Management:**
  - Develop, review, and update travel guidelines to align with business goals and legal compliance.
- **Training and Awareness:**
  - Conduct periodic training sessions for employees and managers to understand travel policies and processes.
- **Support:**
  - Act as the primary point of contact for policy clarification and addressing employee concerns.

Finance Team

- **Expense Management:**

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    - Review, verify, and approve travel expense claims in line with policy guidelines.

- **Budget Monitoring:**
    - Ensure department travel expenditures stay within allocated budgets and alert stakeholders if limits are approached.
- **Compliance:**
    - Oversee adherence to financial regulations and address any discrepancies in claims or reimbursements.

Employee

- **Policy Adherence:**
    - Familiarize themselves with travel guidelines and comply with all requirements.
- **Expense Reporting:**
    - Submit accurate and timely documentation for reimbursement, including receipts and approvals.
- **Sustainable Practices:**
    - Opt for cost-effective and eco-friendly travel options where feasible.

Line Manager

- **Approval Oversight:**
    - Review and approve travel requests, ensuring they are essential and within budget.
- **Guidance:**
    - Advise employees on compliance with travel guidelines and ensure proper planning of trips.
- **Monitoring:**
    - Track team travel activities to ensure alignment with business objectives.

Department Head

- **Strategic Oversight:**

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  - Ensure departmental travel aligns with organizational priorities and business goals.

- **Budget Accountability:**
  - Monitor department travel expenditures and proactively manage budget consumption.

- **Escalation Handling:**
  - Address and resolve disputes or exceptions related to travel within the department.

Guidelines on utilization of Corporate Tie-Ups

- As part of our effort to streamline business travel and ensure comfort and cost efficiency, employees are encouraged to utilise the company recommended options wherever applicable for ticketing, transportation and accommodation.
- Booking through these recommended choices ensures quality service and alignment with our travel policy.
- All employees on official travel may be accommodated in a shared space (may include multi-bedroom apartments, shared suites, or designated shared rooms in hotels), and will be considered primarily for cost-saving purposes, especially for large groups attending conferences, training sessions, or project deployments.
- When shared accommodation is utilized, the highest-grade eligibility among the traveling employees will determine the standard of accommodation. This ensures that all employees benefit from a reasonable level of comfort and security.
- Admin team will be responsible for assistance with reservations.

Medical Emergency Protocol During Travel

Arche Global is committed to ensuring the safety and well-being of its employees during business travel. The following protocol outlines the steps to manage medical emergencies effectively during travel:

Pre-Travel Preparation

- **Emergency Contact Information:**
  - As a general practice, please share or update your emergency contact details with their reporting manager and People Excellence department.

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- Employees are also encouraged to carry their emergency contact numbers and details of the company's designated emergency response team.

- **Medical Insurance Coverage:**
  - Employees are encouraged to carry a softcopy of the insurance policy, including claim procedures and emergency helpline numbers.
- **Medical Clearance and Supplies:**
  - Employees with pre-existing conditions should consult their physician before travel and also it is important to carry essential medications and a basic first aid kit.

During Travel

- **Immediate Response in Case of Emergency:**
  - **Stay Calm:** Assess the situation and avoid panic.
  - **Seek Local Medical Assistance:**
    - Contact local emergency services (e.g., ambulance, hospital).
    - If in a hotel or airport, inform the staff for assistance.
- **Notify Relevant Contacts:**
  - Inform the immediate supervisor and HR.
  - If traveling internationally, contact the local embassy or consulate if needed.
- **Emergency Expenses:**
  - Use your personal funds for immediate medical expenses and retain all receipts for reimbursement.

Post-Emergency Communication

- **Report to the Organisation:**
  - Provide a detailed account of the incident, including medical diagnosis, treatment received, and expenses incurred.
  - Submit all medical reports and receipts for reimbursement through the designated process.

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- **Follow-Up Care:**
  - HR will coordinate with the employee to ensure access to necessary follow-up care and support upon return.

General Safety Guidelines

- Always inform someone from the company or a trusted contact about your itinerary.
- Familiarize yourself with local healthcare facilities and emergency numbers before departure.
- Avoid activities that may pose unnecessary health risks during travel.
- Arche Global is committed to supporting its employees in all circumstances, including medical emergencies. Employees are encouraged to adhere to this protocol to ensure prompt and effective responses to any health- related incidents.

Travel Insurance

- As part of our commitment to ensuring the safety and well-being of all employees traveling internationally for business, Arche Global has implemented a comprehensive **Travel Insurance Policy**. This policy aims to provide coverage for unforeseen circumstances that may arise during your trip, offering peace of mind and financial protection.

Key Highlights of the Travel Insurance Policy

- **Coverage Details:**
  - Medical emergencies, including hospitalization and evacuation.
  - Loss of personal belongings, including passport and luggage.
  - Trip cancellation or delay due to unforeseen events.
- **Eligibility:**
  - All employees traveling internationally on approved business trips are automatically covered under this policy.
- **Process:**
  - Once your travel is approved, the Admin team will coordinate with our insurance provider to activate coverage for your trip.
  - A copy of your travel insurance details, including the policy number and emergency contact information, will be shared with you before departure.

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- **Employee Responsibility:**
    - Ensure you carry a digital copy of the travel insurance documents during your trip.
    - In case of an emergency, promptly contact the insurance provider using the details provided.
    - Notify the HR department of any claims or incidents as soon as possible.
    - We are confident this policy will provide an additional layer of security for your international travel and encourage you to travel confidently while representing Arche Global.

Foreign Exchange Policy for International Travel

This policy outlines the procedures for obtaining and using foreign exchange for business-related expenses during international travel, ensuring compliance with financial regulations and efficient budget management.

Currency Conversion Guidelines

- **Pre-Travel Currency Procurement:**
    - Employees traveling internationally must request foreign exchange through the company's authorized vendor at least 15 days before departure.
    - The Admin team will assist in coordinating the procurement based on the approved travel budget.
- **Exchange Rates:**
    - Currency conversions will be processed at the prevailing market rate on the date of issuance by the authorized vendor. Any fluctuations after issuance will not be adjusted.

Usage Limits

- **Daily Expense Limits:**
    - Employees are advised to stay within the approved daily limits for meals, transportation, and incidentals. These limits will be communicated before travel.
- **Advance Allowances:**

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- The company may provide a pre-approved cash allowance or a company-issued forex card for immediate expenses. Any unutilized amount must be returned within 5 working days or accounted for upon return.

- **Personal Expenses:**
  - Foreign exchange provided by the company is strictly for business-related expenses. Personal expenses must be covered using personal funds.

Reconciliation and Reporting

- **Expense Reporting:**
  - All foreign exchange usage must be documented with receipts and submitted through the expense management tool within 5 working days of returning from the trip.
  - Unused foreign currency must be returned to the authorized vendor or reimbursed to the company within 5 working days upon return.
- **Non-Compliant Usage:**
  - Any unauthorized use of foreign exchange may result in the amount being deducted from the employee's salary and (or) may lead to other disciplinary action.

Claims Submission:

All travel claims must be submitted **within 30 days** of the travel date. **Claims submitted after this period may not be processed.**

Detailed Guidelines on Expense Categories for Reimbursement

To streamline the reimbursement process and ensure clarity, please find below the detailed list of reimbursable and non-reimbursable expenses as per our travel and expense policy.

Reimbursable Expenses

These expenses will be covered by the company if incurred during approved business activities:

- **Transportation**
  - Airfare (economy class or company-approved upgrades)
  - Train fares (based on travel guidelines)

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  - Transportation to/from airports or railway stations, including taxis, ride-hailing services, or shuttles
  - Mileage for personal car usage at approved rates
- **Accommodation**
  - Hotel stays within the company's preferred hotels or budget limits
  - Internet/Wi-Fi charges at hotels for work-related purposes
- **Meals**
  - Business meals within the daily allowance limit

- **Travel Incidentals**
  - Baggage fees for work-related items
  - Parking fees and tolls
  - Visa application fees and travel insurance
- **Other Business-Related Expenses**
  - Conference or event registration fees (if pre-approved)
  - Business phone calls or international roaming charges
  - Office supplies purchased during the trip (if pre-approved)

Non-Reimbursable Expenses

The following expenses are considered personal and will not be reimbursed:

- **Personal Entertainment**
  - Movies, in-flight entertainment, personal video streaming subscriptions
  - Tourist attractions, sightseeing tours, or leisure activities
- **Alcohol and Non-Essential Purchases**
  - Alcoholic beverages unless part of an approved client entertainment expense
  - Non-essential upgrades (e.g., seat upgrades, room upgrades, unless pre-approved)
- **Unapproved Transportation and Accommodation**
  - Travel or hotel arrangements not aligned with company policies
  - Excessive taxi or ride-hailing costs due to personal deviations
- **Miscellaneous**
  - Personal grooming, laundry (unless for trips exceeding 5 days), or spa services
  - Fines, penalties, or traffic tickets incurred during travel
  - Expenses for family or non-business travel companions

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Expense Submission Guidelines

- All claims must be submitted within 30 working days from the completion of travel.
- Scanned copy of original receipts are mandatory for processing reimbursement.
- Reimbursements will not be processed against the cash vouchers
- It is important to produce GST Invoices wherever applicable.

Expense Receipts:

Bills must be submitted for all claimed expenses, even when within eligibility limits. Reimbursement will be based on the lower amount between the bill value and the eligible limit. Eg: If eligibility is Rs.1500/- and the bill value is Rs.2000/-, the lower amount of Rs.1500/- will be processed against the claim.

Process for Expense Claims:

- Employees must submit expense claims through the designated expense management system. Claims must include valid receipts for verification.
- Employees must verify all the claims against the eligibility and policy before submission.
- As a next step, line manager to validate and approve the same for further processing and the final approval will be made by the Department Head.
- Approved claims will be reimbursed directly to the employee's bank account on 25th working date of every month.
- All claims must be submitted and approved on or before 15th working date of every month, to be eligible for payment in that month's cycle.

Exceptional Approval:
In rare and exceptional cases where a cash voucher is deemed necessary:

- The request must be pre-approved by the respective Department Head.
- The Department Head must provide written justification for the exception, detailing the circumstances.
- All exceptional approvals will be reviewed by the Finance Department to ensure compliance with company policies and final approval will be made by the Finance Controller for processing such claims.

Responsibilities:

- **Employees:** Ensure timely and accurate submission of expense claims with all required documentation.
- **Line Manager:** Review and approve expense claims only when the claims are well within the eligibility as per the travel policy

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- **Department Heads:** Review and approve legitimate expense claims and provide exceptional approvals only when absolutely necessary.
- **Finance Department:** Verify claims, process reimbursements, and maintain accurate records for auditing purposes.

Ticket Booking:

- **Flight Tickets**: Must be booked at least **3 weeks** in advance.
- **Train Tickets**: Must be booked at least **1 week** in advance.
- If advance booking is not possible, approval must be obtained from the line manager with proper justification, followed by approvals from the Head of Department (HOD) and CEO.
- For all travel and accommodation booking outside of the employee's current work location (intercity), has to be approved by the line manager and department head.
- Travel, accommodation and expense claims will not be processed without necessary approvals.

Travel Advance Clearance:

- Employee can request for travel advance as per the defined eligibility by stating the business justification for this request.
- All travel advance has to be approved by Department Head, HR Head and Finance Controller.
- All such request has to be approved 1 week in advance, for Finance department to process travel advance to the concerned employees bank account.
- Any travel advance taken must be cleared within 5 working days upon return. Failing which, equivalent amount will be deducted from the respective employee's salary and calls for disciplinary action.

Preferred Mode of Travel:

- **Bus or Road Travel**: Please avoid bus or road travel for safety reasons, especially during nighttime.
- **Overnight Journeys**: Should only be by train for optimal rest and safety.
- **Working Hours**: For all intercity travels, strictly avoid travel during working hours to minimize disruption to work schedules.

- Employees should **refrain from working remotely during travel** and for exceptional situations, remote work during travel must be approved by the Department Head and HR Head in advance.

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- Employees are expected to mark "Outdoor" in the HRMS for all the days, during travel for business reasons.
- **Journeys Less Than 8 Hours:** For journey with a travel time of 8 hours or less or in the case of overnight travel, train travel is to be used as the preferred mode of transportation.
- Exceptions to these guidelines should be supported with a strong business justification and must receive prior approval from your line manager, HOD, and the CEO.

Team Lunches and Customer Engagements:

- **Team Lunch**: Can be availed once per quarter and has to be budgeted in advance, with prior approval from HR Head, Finance Controller and CEO.
- **Customer Engagement Budgets**: Must be budgeted every quarter with business justification and require prior approval from Department Head, Finance Controller and CEO.

Annual Travel Budget Planning and Monitoring Guidelines

- Each department head is required to prepare a detailed travel expense budget for the entire year.
- This budget should cover all anticipated business trips, including transportation, accommodation, and other reimbursable expenses.
- Please submit your department's travel budget to the Finance team by 1st week of March, every year.

Monitoring and Managing Budget Utilization

- Line managers are encouraged to review and approve travel requests mindfully, ensuring alignment with departmental priorities and budget constraints.
- Managers must track travel expenses regularly to avoid overconsumption of allocated budgets.

Proactive Measures for Budget Adjustment

- If an employee or department approaches 80-90% of their travel budget, it is crucial to initiate a proactive discussion with the Finance team and HR to assess the situation.

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- Consider rescheduling, reprioritizing, or optimizing travel to manage within the allocated funds effectively.

Guidelines for Approval

- All travel requests must be justified with a clear business purpose and reviewed against the department's remaining budget.
- Unplanned or ad-hoc travel exceeding the budget must be pre-approved by the respective department head and the Finance Controller.

By adhering to these guidelines, we can ensure responsible budget management while supporting the organization's operational needs.

Guidelines for Combining Personal Travel with Business Trips

We recognise that employees may wish to combine personal travel with business trips. While we support flexibility and work-life balance, we have established clear guidelines to ensure such arrangements are managed responsibly and align with company policies.

Approval Requirements

- Employees must obtain prior written approval from their reporting manager and HR Head for any personal travel extension to a business trip.
- The request should include:
  - Business travel dates and location
  - Personal travel dates and location
  - A statement confirming that personal travel will not interfere with business responsibilities.

Cost-Sharing Arrangements

- **Company-Covered Costs:**
  - Expenses directly related to the business portion of the trip, including airfare for employee (round-trip to the business destination), accommodation for employee during business dates, and work-related transportation, will be covered by the company.
- **Employee-Covered Costs:**
  - Any additional expenses incurred due to the personal travel extension (e.g., extra accommodation nights, transportation to personal destinations, personal meals) must be borne by the employee.

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- If the return travel route differs from the business itinerary, the employee must pay any fare difference.

Expense Reporting and Reimbursement

- Employees must submit expenses related to the business portion of the trip separately from personal expenses.
- Clearly label and document all receipts and provide an explanation for any combined costs.

Compliance with Travel Policies

- Employees must continue to adhere to company policies on travel behaviour, data security, and reimbursement during the business portion of the trip.
- Personal travel must not disrupt business commitments or the company's operational priorities.

Insurance and Liability

- The company's travel insurance coverage applies only during the business portion of the trip. Employees are responsible for arranging their own insurance for personal travel.

Request Process

- Submit a formal request to your reporting manager and HR Head at least 30 days in advance of the travel date.
- Include a detailed itinerary and estimated costs for both business and personal portions of the trip.

Escalation Process for Resolving Claims or Policy Interpretation Disputes

To ensure fairness and transparency, we have established an **escalation process** for resolving disputes or conflicts related to claims or policy interpretations. This structured approach allows employees to address concerns effectively and ensures timely resolution.

Steps to Resolve Disputes

Initial Discussion with Immediate Manager

- The first step is to discuss the issue with your immediate manager.
- Clearly outline the nature of the dispute (e.g., claim rejection, policy misunderstanding) and provide relevant supporting documents or evidence.
- Many issues can be resolved at this level through clarification

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Submit a Formal Request to People Excellence Department

- If unresolved, escalate the matter to the People Excellence department
- Submit a formal request via email, detailing the issue, previous steps taken, and any documentation to support your case.
- The People Excellence team will review your concern and respond within 5 working days.

Appeal to the Escalation Committee

- For complex or unresolved disputes, employees may appeal to the Escalation Committee.
- The committee, comprising representatives from HR Head, Finance Controller, and senior management, will conduct a comprehensive review and issue a final decision.
- Appeals must be submitted in writing, including all supporting evidence and a summary of previous steps.
- The Committee may require 10 working days to evaluate the concern and provide final resolution.

Final Resolution

- The decision made by the Escalation Committee is considered final and binding.

General Guidelines

- Maintain a professional and constructive approach throughout the resolution process.
- Ensure all communication is documented for transparency and record-keeping.
- Avoid bypassing steps in the escalation process, as this may delay resolution.

Training on Travel Eligibility and Guidelines

To ensure that employees and managers remain informed about travel policies, eligibility criteria, and compliance requirements, People Excellence department will impart **Training and Refresher Sessions** on our **Travel Policy**.

These sessions are designed to enhance understanding, address common challenges, and keep everyone updated on any policy changes.

Why This Training Is Important

- **Clarity on Travel Eligibility:** Understand who qualifies for business travel, approval processes, and documentation requirements.

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- **Policy Compliance:** Ensure adherence to company guidelines on travel expenses, reimbursements, and foreign exchange.
- **Efficiency and Cost-Effectiveness:** Learn best practices for planning and managing travel within budget limits.
- **Updates on Policy Changes:** Stay informed about new or revised policies to prevent misunderstandings or compliance issues.

Training Details

- **Frequency:** Sessions will be conducted bi-annually and as needed for major updates.
- **Target Audience:** All employees and managers involved in business travel or expense approvals.
- **Format:** Online sessions, in-person workshops, or recorded modules (based on availability).

Periodic Review Cycle for Travel s Reimbursement Policy

- To ensure that our **Travel s Reimbursement Policy** remains effective, relevant, and aligned with current business needs and industry trends, People Excellence department will perform a comprehensive review **annually**.
- The review process will involve input from key stakeholders, including People Excellence, Finance Controller, Department Heads, to incorporate feedback and address evolving requirements.
- Employees are also encouraged to share their experiences and suggestions regarding the travel and reimbursement policy to People Excellence department at any time during the year.

Guidelines for Sustainable Travel Practices

As part of Arche Global' commitment to sustainability and reducing our environmental footprint, we encourage employees to adopt environmentally conscious practices during business travel. To support this effort, we have introduced guidelines for sustainable travel options and considerations.

Encouraged Sustainable Travel Practices

- **Opt for Eco-Friendly Transportation:**
    - Whenever feasible, prioritize trains over flights for shorter trips as they significantly reduce carbon emissions.
    - Choose direct flights over connecting ones to minimize fuel consumption and emissions.

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- **Carpooling and Shared Transportation:**
    - Use shared transportation services or carpooling when commuting for business purposes to reduce individual vehicle usage, without compromising on the business outcomes

Eco-Friendly Accommodations

- **Sustainable Hotels:**
    - When booking hotels, prioritize those with eco-friendly certifications, energy-efficient practices, or sustainability programs.
    - Use accommodations listed under the company's recommended eco-friendly options, where available.
- **Minimize Resource Usage:**
    - Conserve energy and water by reusing linens and towels during hotel stays.

Carbon Offsets

- Employees are encouraged to participate in carbon offset programs when booking flights.
- The company will evaluate options to include carbon offsetting in approved travel itineraries.

Virtual Alternatives to Travel

- Where possible, consider virtual meetings or conferences to reduce the need for travel.

Policy Alignment and Training

- Managers and employees should align travel decisions with these guidelines to contribute to the company's sustainability goals.
- Training sessions on sustainable travel practices will be offered as part of our policy orientation and updates.

Guidelines for Non-Compliance with Travel and Reimbursement Policy

Arche Global is committed to ensuring that all travel and reimbursement activities align with our established policies and guidelines. Adherence to these policies ensures transparency, accountability, and efficient resource management. To maintain this standard, we have outlined procedures and consequences for instances of non-compliance with the Travel and Reimbursement Policy.

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Non-compliance includes, but is not limited to:

- Submitting claims for unauthorized or non-reimbursable expenses.
- Failing to obtain prior approvals for travel or related expenditures.
- Misrepresenting expenses or falsifying receipts.
- Not adhering to cost-saving measures, such as selecting eco-friendly or cost-efficient options.
- Combining personal and business travel without proper approval or cost allocation.

Reporting and Addressing Non-Compliance

Review Process:

- All travel and reimbursement claims are subject to review by the Finance team to ensure they meet policy requirements.

Notification of Issues:

- If a claim or travel activity is found to be non-compliant, the concerned employee will be notified in writing, specifying the issue and requesting clarification.

Consequences of Non-Compliance

- **Deduction or Denial of Claims:**
  - Non-compliant expenses will not be reimbursed, and any amount disbursed in error must be repaid by the employee.
- **Formal Warning:**
  - Repeated violations may result in a formal warning recorded in the employee's file.
- **Disciplinary Action:**
  - Serious or fraudulent violations, such as falsifying receipts, may lead to further disciplinary measures, including suspension or termination of employment.

Escalation Process

Employees have the right to appeal non-compliance decisions by following the Escalation Process (refer to the escalation policy). Appeals must include supporting evidence or explanations and be submitted within 3 working days of notification.

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Prevention and Support

To minimize non-compliance, employees and managers are encouraged to:

- Familiarize themselves with the latest travel and reimbursement policies.
- Attend periodic training sessions.
- Seek clarification from People Excellence or Finance before initiating travel or submitting claims, whenever required

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